Final Policy Brief: Addressing Traffic Violence through Immediate Actionable Metrics

Part 1: Defining the Problem and Justifying Local Intervention

City Council members, I'm writing this because I keep noticing how people in our city talk about the same problems over and over, and it always feels like nothing really changes. We have all these big ideas about the future, and we make plans that sound hopeful, but when you actually walk around the city you can tell a lot of people are frustrated. The main issue facing our city streets right now is traffic violence, which means that our streets are designed in ways that make danger feel normal, even though crashes are preventable events. The streets feel unsafe, traffic keeps getting worse, and even the smaller things, like crossing an intersection, feel harder than they should. This is an urgent problem that needs action now, not promises about transformation decades from now.

The magnitude of this issue is huge because it touches everything, from public health to how connected people feel to their city. In the United States, traffic deaths are a significant problem, and even though cars are becoming safer thanks to features like crumple zones and airbags, too many people still die in crashes. For example, in 2016, 37,461 people were killed in crashes on U.S. roadways, which was an increase from the year before. This shows that despite safer technology in cars, the problem is persisting. Speeding is a major factor in fatal crashes, being a factor in 27 percent of motor vehicle crash deaths in 2015. Speed is a direct cause of how severe a death or injury is, so when vehicles go faster, outcomes are worse for pedestrians and cyclists. The problem is especially bad for vulnerable people; more than one-quarter of fatal traffic fatalities in the U.S. occur among motorcyclists, pedestrians, and cyclists. People of color are also disproportionately affected, with African Americans and Latinos being 60 percent and 43 percent more likely, respectively, to be killed in traffic crashes while walking than white Americans. These traffic deaths are often the result of historical neglect and underinvestment in basic pedestrian infrastructure like sidewalks and protected crossings. (Schwartz)

There are a few carefully considered reasons why this issue persists, even though everyone says they want safer streets. One principal reason we witness these trends worsening is owing to car culture. Historically, cars have been tied to American identity, freedom, and choice, and the 1950s were a golden age for car ownership where families widely adopted them. Cars

were also instrumental in transforming the urban landscape, leading to the demise of streetcars and the proliferation of shopping centers outside of traditional downtowns. Because the car is so central to American life, asking people to drive slower or support road redesigns feels personal to them. This cultural attachment gives cars a lot of power and makes it hard to change the way our streets are prioritized. (Rybczynski)

A second principal reason the issue persists is that we rely on weak indicators and long-term planning that ignores the present reality. City planning often relies on strategic plans and long-term visions that promise transformation decades from now, which allows basic services to fail today and drains resources from building for the here and now . We use metrics that are either delayed, taking years to produce data, or are designed more for political performance than for actual policy effectiveness. An example of a weak indicator is transport mode split, which measures how many people walk, bike, or take transit. While that's a good long-term goal, changes to mode split depend on complex systemic shifts that take decades, and in the meantime, streets are getting more dangerous. Relying on indicators that take years to demonstrate progress is an example of planning for the "future" which has become an excuse not to act for the here and now.

Next, we need to consider how and why the role of government should be called upon, particularly the power of local government. The government needs to intervene because the current reality is full of urgent problems, like unsafe streets and reduced accessibility. The role of government, and specifically local government, is necessary to solve issues that affect the entire community, and urban planning has a role in making sure transportation is safe, reliable, and accessible for everyone. The rationale for local government intervention is strong because local officials have control over the specific, timely actions needed to change streets, like setting average speeds and implementing physical changes. The profession of urban planning should more aggressively intervene to ensure safe streets because transportation engineers are responsible for designing streets and infrastructure to ensure the safe and reliable movement of goods and people. (The Handy Engineering Book)

In the past, the city and the urban planning profession have aimed to "fix" traffic safety often by focusing on educational campaigns or incremental changes, but these efforts have been limited. The focus on long-term goals like increasing mode share has not been going well, as

most U.S. cities have barely moved the needle. Problems are continuing to outstrip efforts to make things better because we keep making decisions based on speculative futures instead of fixing the lived reality of dangerous streets today. We need to switch from weak, long-term metrics to actionable indicators that are precise, timely, and within local control.

Therefore, I am articulating a clear KPI that should be used to effectively measure progress on traffic violence, one that can demonstrate traction in the next two years and guide future decision-making.

The proposed Strategic KPI is: Average Vehicle Speed on Neighborhood Streets and Number of Completed Traffic Calming Installations.

This KPI is actually two objective measures working together, showing both the immediate impact and the raw output of work.

1. Average Vehicle Speed on Neighborhood Streets at Peak Hours: This should be measured street by street using short-term sensors and reported daily or weekly. This KPI is strong because speed is a direct cause of death severity, making it objective, timely, and within local control. We don't have to wait years for long-term changes like mode shift to know if our interventions are working. We can show average speeds falling from 30 to 25 miles per hour on a certain corridor within a month of intervention, which provides immediate proof something worked.

2. Number of Blocks that Implemented Physical Traffic Calming or Protected Crossings in the Last Six Months: This KPI counts actual physical installations, not just promises or long-term plans. It ties money and work directly to visible change and prevents bureaucracies from delaying action. If a council member wants credit, they can see a rolling dashboard of blocks completed, showing people crossing safer today versus last quarter.

These indicators are better than weak metrics because they are hard to dilute, tied to operational levers the city can pull, and force action now instead of waiting. They stop the future from being an excuse for inaction. For an elected official, using live speed sensors and fleet procurement orders can show immediate movement (tomorrow timeline). Using installation

counts and early speed trends can show momentum (next month timeline), and incident severity data can demonstrate real outcomes (next year timeline). These objective measures allow us to replace subjective judgment with numerical indicators of performance. Strong intent isn't enough; what matters is rallying behind objective indicators to demonstrate that things are actually moving in the right direction. We need things that are simple and hard to fake, just like using salmon populations as an indicator for environmental health. This focus on timely and visible progress is key to rebuilding public trust and demonstrating that local government is responsive. The city planning department has the ability to implement these metrics by leveraging transportation engineers, who are responsible for analyzing traffic trends and creating roadways that are safe. This KPI ensures that the urgency of unsafe streets is addressed with measurable, practical change right away. The reliance on old, slow metrics has caused stagnation, and these new, fast metrics are how we move past that. (The Handy Engineering Book)

Part 2: Policy Prescription for Action and Overcoming Stagnation

Drawing from the action-oriented theory of Policy Entrepreneurship (Mintrom), I am providing a compelling case for a policy prescription that can gain traction and break through the stagnation caused by past slow efforts. Policy entrepreneurship suggests that a good idea isn't enough, it has to become other people's idea too, and requires strategic framing, coalition-building, and timing to succeed. This theory helps explain how new ideas can be socialized and come into favor. (King)

Policy Prescription: The Immediate Safe Streets Initiative (ISSI)

The ISSI is a policy that requires the Department of Public Works and the City Planner’s office to focus 80% of their street safety budget for the next two years on rapid, demonstrable projects tied directly to the short-term KPIs identified in Part 1.

The focused action that an elected official can act on immediately is two-fold:

1. Mandate Rapid Installation: Require the completion of physical traffic calming installations or protected crossings on a minimum of 50 blocks within the next six

months. This ties the budget directly to the Number of Completed Traffic Calming Installations KPI.

2. Mandate Fleet Composition Change: Introduce new procurement rules that require 50% of all new city fleet vehicle purchases and contracted commercial fleet vehicles to be small or lightweight vehicles, starting next month. This addresses the problem that bigger vehicles mean worse outcomes for pedestrians and cyclists, and fleet composition is a budget line item an official can change quickly.

This policy prescription is different from past efforts, which often got bogged down in long-term comprehensive plans or focused solely on public education. Past efforts have been limited because the bureaucracy defends outdated rules and relies on long-term indicators that justify delay and complexity. By focusing on immediate, measurable outputs, the ISSI overcomes these. It's a way to ensure that resources are building for today, not just hypothetically for the future.

The ISSI will work because we will tie rewards and penalties to the new, rapid indicators. For example, the City Council can attach a small budget bonus to the Public Works department if they meet or exceed the 50-block installation target within six months. Conversely, if the procurement teams fail to meet the fleet composition targets, the council can reallocate discretionary funds. This use of the carrot and the stick gets attention and motivates institutions to perform based on measured performance. We need to make sure we are feeding the right, timely information to the institutions so they can ask better questions and make better decisions.

Applying Policy Entrepreneurship to the ISSI is essential for gaining traction. Policy entrepreneurs, as discussed by Mintrom, know that strategic framing is critical. Instead of simply: we are lowering speed limits, the official should frame it as: We are protecting our kids and making neighborhoods calmer and safer today, which is a message that resonates with broader audiences like community members and stakeholders. Timing is also crucial. When a serious crash happens, that is when people are paying attention and are ready for change. Policy entrepreneurs need to be ready to introduce the ISSI at those moments to ensure the idea gains momentum.

We must also overcome pushback. When I talked about this idea with classmates, some thought focusing on short-term indicators makes everything too narrow, like we'd ignore the bigger picture. If a councilmember pushed back and said these indicators oversimplify the situation or might take energy away from long-term planning, I would explain that the point isn't to replace long-term goals like achieving overall mode shift. It's about giving them better tools to understand what is happening right now. You cannot make good big decisions if you are basically flying blind in the short term.

The rationale for why the ISSI is different is that it rejects the idea that speculative futures can justify neglecting lived reality. It specifically addresses traffic safety by targeting the speed of vehicles (Average Speed KPI) and the inherent danger of large vehicles (Fleet KPI). Furthermore, it uses the Number of Blocks Calmed KPI to force visible, physical change, ensuring that policy isn't just a glossy press release but actual work being completed. Autonomous Vehicles might eventually reduce crashes by mitigating human error like distraction or aggressive driving, but that is far in the future, and we need to deal with the urgency of speed and safety now. We cannot use the future possibility of vehicles as an excuse for inaction today, just as long-term mode split shouldn't be an excuse for dangerous streets.

The ISSI policy actions directly support Part 1 by providing the mechanism to achieve the measurable progress promised by the KPIs. By mandating 50 physical installations in six months, we immediately start lowering the Average Vehicle Speed on those neighborhood streets, providing rapid, measurable feedback that the intervention worked (the tomorrow timeline). The mandated shift toward smaller city fleet vehicles also provides a quick, measurable policy win in procurement records by next month, directly addressing the impact of vehicle size on safety outcomes.

The agency is assigned clearly to key actors:

1. City Councilmembers: They must approve the ISSI policy, fund the budget bonuses tied to performance, and use the daily/weekly KPI dashboard to guide their decision-making and hold staff accountable. They must champion the policy by telling stories about the safety results and showing a parent crossing a newly calmed block while pointing to the speed readings that fell.

2. Municipal Planner/Department of Public Works: They are assigned the task of analyzing the sensor data and rapidly executing the 50-block physical calming installations.
3. Procurement Teams: They are assigned the responsibility of meeting the fleet composition targets to reduce the overall danger presented by city vehicles.

This approach of focusing on objective, precise, and fast indicators, supported by the strategic framing and timing of Policy Entrepreneurship, is the only way to ensure that our city is truly making progress on street safety, rather than just talking about it. People want to feel like their city listens and responds, and having numbers that change quickly might help council members react quicker too.

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